

Efficient Data Storage Systems

Practical Assignment: Article Review and Discussion

University of Minho
2026

General Information

- Each group must consist of 3 members;
- The article bidding deadline is March 6, 2026.
- The first article review must be submitted by April 24, 2026.
- The online discussion and revision update period ends on May 4, 2026.
- The in-person discussion will take place on May 8 during class. Each group may prepare a small set of slides as supporting material for the discussion. Details regarding the time allocated to each group will be provided by the teaching staff in due course.
- This assignment represents 40% of the final grade and has a minimum passing grade of 10 points.

Objectives

The objective of this assignment includes the comprehension, critical reflection, review, and discussion of two scientific articles per group. The final grade will take into account the different steps of the assignment, namely the ability to understand the articles, as well as to critically review and discuss them.

Phases

Group formation and registration on the *hotcrp* platform. Group formation must be carried out through the Blackboard platform. The *hotcrp* platform will be used for article selection, review, and online discussion, available at: <https://uminho-sade26.hotcrp.com>. The teaching staff will send an invitation (to the institutional email) to one student per group to access the platform. This student must set up the account and share the credentials with the remaining group members.

Article selection. Article selection is carried out through the *hotcrp* platform using the *paper bidding* mechanism. Each group must indicate its preference for each article suggested by the teaching staff. Preferences must be indicated according to the rules described on the platform. Article assignment to each group is performed automatically by the platform, taking into account the stated preferences, while also ensuring that all articles are assigned reviewers.

First review. Each group must review the two articles assigned to them and submit an initial review of both through the platform. The review should address the following questions:

- What problems are being addressed?

- What are the scientific contributions in relation to the state of the art?
- What is the design and what are the key characteristics of the proposed solution?
- What methodology is used to evaluate the solution?
- What are the main results (e.g., experimental) that validate the solution?
- What are the strengths and limitations of the solution?

Based on the strengths and weaknesses, as well as the novelty of the article, the group must also indicate a decision regarding the acceptance or rejection of the article, consistent with their discussion.

Online discussion period. Using the same platform, groups assigned the same articles must engage in an online discussion. The main goal is to reach a final consensus decision. Updates to the initial reviews and to the discussion must be submitted on the *hotcrp* platform.

In-person presentation and discussion of the articles. Finally, an in-person discussion will be held, article by article, where each group will present a summary of their review and will respond to questions from classmates and instructors.